

ISLES OF MYSTERY

THE *New York Herald* publishes the following remarkable account of the discovery of mementoes of a dead past and an extinct race in the Pacific:—The deserted Channel Islands of the Pacific, which lie some twenty miles off the southern coast of California, have at last undergone a thorough exploration by Professor Charles Frederick Holden, with the result that much of absorbing interest regarding the extinct inhabitants of these lovely isles has been discovered. He visited San Nicolas, Santa Catalina, and San Clemente, and made many excavations and many rich finds.

Giants once lived in the exquisitely lovely Channel Islands, for many skeletons have been found there more than seven feet high. Tradition has it that the warlike tribes of the Aleutian Islands came down in boats more than a century ago and practically exterminated the Channel Islanders. Certain is it that most of the unhappy wretches met death by violence, for nearly all the skulls discovered are crushed by blows from blunt instruments. The club is the weapon of the Aleutian savage, and this seems to fit the tradition.

A few escaped, and up to about sixty years ago the remnants of the tribe were still living on San Nicolas. In 1835 the Franciscans of the Santa Barbara mission, learning that there were but six or so of the strange Indian race then living, determined to rescue them. They went over in a sloop and succeeded in getting all on board.

At the last moment an Indian woman returned for her child, and, one of the frequent storms of the Channel Islands springing up the sloop was driven away. It went on the rocks of Point Conception and all on board were lost.

So only this woman was left, and she was soon forgotten.

In 1851, however, Captain George Nidever visited the Island to hunt sea otter, and was amazed to find human footprints in the sand. Two years later he returned to investigate the matter, and succeeded in capturing the remaining Indian, now an old woman.

She was dressed in birdskins, and was engaged in scraping blubber from a seal. They took her to Santa Barbara, where she lived for several years, and was known far and wide as "the lone woman from San Nicolas." But she never learned enough English to be able to tell anything of the life and the tradition of her strange race.

Professor Holden, in his exploration just concluded, found many large monads in San Nicolas, one three hundred feet long by fifty wide, composed of abalone shells, which were brought from the sea two miles distant, thus showing evidence

of a large population.

TELLTALE DISCOVERIES.

He found objects of stone, bone, and shell piled in heaps. There were pendants, rings, beads, and curious objects in pearl among them, proving that the extinct people loved ornamentation. That they played games was shown by the finding of perforated and oval stones, and many small and peculiarly-shaped instruments. Some of the mortars picked up were very high and narrow, others so heavy there was great difficulty in rolling them down to the ship. One showed evidence of ornamentation with abalone.

Sculptured toms of miniature sea lions and whales carved from serpentine prove a love of art in the aborigines. According to Professor Holden the islanders depended for food on abalone, fish, and possibly roots. Consequently they belonged to an advanced period of the stone age.

San Clemente, twenty miles long by three wide, Professor Holden found contained much evidence of ancient habitation. Possibly three hundred years ago it had a large population. One square mile of its area was covered with skeletons, shells, and ancient implements and mortars, some ones weighing one hundred pounds. Santa Catalina is a high mountain ridge, the only landing places being the mouths of canyons.

Up the canyons Professor Holden located fifty sites which had been occupied by aborigines. Under a small summer resort hotel recently built

there he found implements of all kinds. On San Clemente numerous bone implements were unearthed, among them needles and awls for punching skin. Several mortars found there and on San Catalina show an aesthetic taste among the

people, for they are highly decorated with mosaic of abalone. A sword handle was decorated with a plate made of abalone.

Professor Holden declares that the islands were inhabited for many centuries, for he found heaps of abalone shell on the sea-shore, covered with twenty feet of a deposit, which he calculates required centuries for its formation.

The islands have been a mine of archaeological treasure ever since 1872, when the first systematic exploration was made by Mr W. G. W. Harford, of the United States Coast Survey, who subsequently exhibited his small but valuable collection to admiring scientific friends in the East. Dr. W. H. Dall, of the National Museum, paid a visit to the islands in the following year, and also secured some wonderfully interesting specimens of primitive art. In 1875 the Smithsonian Institution sent out a party of scientific men, with Mr Paul Schumacher in charge, and these gentlemen in their explorations discovered several very remarkable and extensive burial grounds, as well as large ancient village sites, buried deep under the castaway shells of edible mollusks.

TELLS OF A DEAD PAST.

From the graveyards were unearthed a large number of skeletons, each surrounded by marvelous examples of the products and handiwork of the long past dead.

The graves, as described by these investigators

and others, make an interesting story of themselves. The skeletons lay crowded together in every conceivable position, sometimes superimposed three or four deep, those below, forgotten and unmarked, ruthlessly disturbed to make room for last interment. Some of the graves had rude boxes constructed of the huge flat bones of whales, in which the dead were deposited. The early sea captains related gruesome tales of the islands, where, within yawning skeletons of whales, lay the grinning and bleached bones of men, exposed to view by the ceaseless shifting of the sands.

In the department of prehistoric archaeology of the Smithsonian Institution are to be found collected together all the results of the above expedition and that of a number of others, and the aggregate produces a startling revelation as to the possibilities of those faraway islands in valuable ethnologic finds.

One type of the remarkable finds made in the groves is the gigantic soapstone, or steatite, pots, called ollas in the South-west, which stand absolutely alone as monuments to the cleverness of the early inhabitants of these islands. Some of them are fully two and one-half feet in diameter, almost globular in form, with very thin walls, and carefully polished over their entire inner and outer surfaces.

It is astounding how these ancient peoples carved and modelled such symmetrical and fragile vases from this material, but, nevertheless, fully three-

fourths of the vessels used for cooking and ceremonial purposes were adroitly fashioned from it. For most of the pipes, gorgets, mortars, animal figures, pendants, net sinkers and the like the same stone was utilized.

A shudderingly facetious use for some of these colossal stone jars was as a headgear for the dead. Numbers of skeletons were unearthed with skulls completely encased in the orifices of the vases.

Beautiful haliotis shells, with their inner walls plated with pearly and shining nacre, were quite common finds with the burials, and some of them have been found partially filled with bitumen, a substance which seems to have had a very wide range of utility among the natives as a pitch for caulking the wooden boats, as paint for decorating the body and earthenware vases, as handles for brushes, and as cement for holding in place arrow and spear points.

BEADS AND ORNAMENTS.

An intensely interesting insight into the foibles and vain weakness for personal adornment among these long past people is exemplified in a large and varied collection of shell beads, cut from the central shaft of big conch shells; shell discs, some slightly engraved with designs; shell plates, carved and pierced for suspension, and, the most interesting of all, the paint cups, of shell and steatite, half filled with bright red ochres and black shining asphalt which were used in those ages, dimmed by time, to hideously decorate the

faces and body of the shy and coy maiden, perhaps as well as that of her sinister and warlike lover.

Living upon an island home, the inhabitants rarely obtained much of their sustenance from the surrounding waters; and, in evidence of these piscatorial proclivities many remnants of carefully-constructed canoes have been unearthed from time to time by the various parties who have delved in the burial places, and it appears that many of these canoes became the last resting-places or sepulchres for the dead.

Stone net sinkers have been found in such profusion as to leave no doubt as to the persistent avocation of the fishermen, and in the Smithsonian collection appear numbers of finely-cut shellfish hooks, carved out of the sea shells in almost complete semicircles, with sharp barbs, which would do credit to some of more modern manufacture.

Half-a-dozen hair brushes, examples of which are still to be seen in use among a few southwestern tribes, were unearthed from graves. They are made of the fibre of the soap plant, or a species of yucca, bunched together in the semblance of a miniature whisk broom, the top or handle formed by heavily coating one end for several inches with bitumen.

With such beautiful collections already gained from this garden spot for archaeologists, it is apparent that a vast amount of the richest and most valuable objective evidence obtainable in the United States must lie waiting for the hands of

United States must lie waiting for the hands of the enthusiastic scientist. Professor Helden is the fortunate scientist who has availed of the rich field that has so long awaited a patient investigator. He has brought back with him a wonderland of curiosities, which he is now engaged in studying.

A MELANCHOLY SPOT.

San Clemente is the only one of the islands that is at all visited. A few sportsmen go there yearly for the magnificent bird shooting and unsurpassed sea-fishing. The others are rarely ever approached. San Nicolas is the most interesting of them all. It is partly covered with drifting sand now, but its grassy and wooded portions are the home of thousands of wild sheep. Hundreds of immense white pelicans can be seen at almost any season promenading sedately on the narrow beach at Coral Harbour, the only safe approach to the island. There is one habitation on the island, a dilapidated shed, built by the Chinese, who come at intervals to gather the exquisitely lovely shells on the shore or to shear the wild sheep.

The shell mounds, of which there are hundreds, are made up of astonishing varieties of mollusks, the bones of innumerable fish of all species found in the neighbouring waters and the bones of seals, sea elephants, whales, otters, birds, and foxes. There must have been a time when the island was luxuriantly forested, for very many of the animals whose bones are found there could not live on the island in its present desolate condition.

It is a melancholy spot for the visitor, for every acre of it has its tale or tales of an extinct civili-

sation. That the people that once enlivened its shores and cliffs were peaceful is shown by the absence of weapons of offence. The weapons found there are those used in the household and the chase.

These gentle savages were fishermen by choice, and they must have been sturdy and persistent whalers, judging by the myriad remains of these deep sea leviathans that Professor Holden found upon the islands. The great bones of whales were built into rudely artistic structures so compactly that they have withstood the ravages of storm and sand for centuries.

The only actual record of this interesting savage race that we have previous to the disastrous attempt by the missionaries to remove the remnants of it, as told above, is the log of Captain Juan Rodriguez Cabrillo, the Portuguese navigator, who sailed up the Californian coast in 1542. He stopped a day or two at each of the Channel Islands, and reported that they were inhabited by a "vigorous and lusty race of natives, who thronged the shores of the bays and headlands," and seemed greatly mystified by the ship. The islands remain, but the natives are no more.
